particularly about events from Bikaner to Sri Lanka. For the later chapters, I had to reach out across the years to the present incumbents of the appointments I had once held. One such person who comes to mind is Maj Gen Vikas Lakhera, who till recently was the Inspector General Assam Rifles (North) at Kohima, who not only filled in the blanks but also gave me an update on the prevailing sentiments, particularly in the aftermath of adversative operations carried out by the Security Forces. I was acutely conscious of the fact that as a retired officer, I should not ask for any information from any serving officer that could put them in an awkward position. This was particularly true for Lt Gens Paramjit Sangha and BS Raju, who were my Director Generals of Military Operations and closely involved in the Galwan affair.

More than once, I wondered what style to adopt and the detail I should go into. In this, my wife, Veena, had an important role to play, in ensuring that I found just the right balance. Too much detail would not only be boring for a military reader, but equally of little relevance to a lay reader. The narrative had to be much more free-flowing and not the cut-and-dried style of military appreciations. I have to thank her, therefore, for this very practical advice, which I am sure will contribute a lot in making the narrative hit the right spot for a range of readers across all walks of life and ages. I did not write the book in a strict chronological order, but I did the chapter on Battalion Command first, which was the closest to my heart. This I showed to my daughters, Isha and Amala, my sister-in-law, Uma, and her husband, Hitesh, as also Veena's friend Shailaja, who has been a childhood friend. Their feedback both in terms of readability and content was most valuable, particularly Shailaja's feedback that it left her wanting for more. Thus encouraged, I was able to proceed apace.

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